

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 114

Culture (OWC): [Tonga \(FQ12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1994-1995

Coverage Date: 1950-2003

Place Coverage

Sinafala village, central-eastern Southern province, Zambia

Section Title(S)

The Ambivalence of Grandsons and Rescue by Daughters

In contrast to the attention given her by her daughters, the grandsons expressed much more ambivalence about their grandmother. During one of my visits with Malala we sat next to her house in the garden of bullrush millet that she had planted during the rainy season of 1995–96. Mister had decided that he would clear an even larger area adjacent to Malala's garden. Throughout our conversation, Malala turned to Mister and made comments about the trees he was cutting and threatening him with retaliation should one of those trees fall on her millet and crush it. Mister responded with sarcastic chuckles and teasing pleas for some of her tobacco. This grandmother-grandson relationship represents a common form of “joking relations,” as research throughout Africa documents (Colson 1951; Murdock 1959; Stucki 1995). Yet despite the joviality of their exchange, Mister, as well as his “cousin” Fosten, frequently veered from the norm of respect for elders.

Fosten, the extremely active and vocal leader of the local Seventh-Day Adventist church, rarely visited his grandmother or gave her assistance (although the meals his mother brought to Malala came from Fosten's food supplies). However, he did make a trip to her hut one day. On one of my journeys out of the village I left a 2.5-liter jug of water for Malala. Malala already had such a jug from which she drank and bathed, but it was broken, so that at most it could contain only a liter and a half. One of Mister's wives had

123
[Observation In Research](#)

132
[Climate](#)

273
[Alcoholic Beverages](#)

603
[Grandparents And Grandchildren](#)

685
[Property Offenses](#)

888
[Status And Treatment Of The Aged](#)

312
[Water Supply](#)

415
[Utensils](#)

602

the responsibility of bringing water to Malala, but she thought it a great burden, and Malala received water perhaps once a week if she was lucky. Malala described bribing some of Mister's young children to collect water for her by giving them a treat when she had something (when I gave her gifts of sugar she could then use that to entice the children into helping her). So, according to the gossip, about an hour after my departure from the village, leaving the new jug with Malala, Fosten arrived at her doorstep and took the jug back to his own homestead. Malala, in her early eighties, almost blind and physically frail, could not defend her rights to the jug. Fosten added the jug to his collection of property in his homestead.

[Kin Relationships](#)[797](#)[Missions](#)

A few months later, deep into the drought of 1995–96 when it was clear that rainy-season fields would yield no grain, Malala experienced another crisis instigated by a grandson. Without any warning, or words to his mothers or brothers, Mister packed up his homestead, including both  115 wives and all the children, and moved to their gardens on the lakeshore. During intensive weeding and bird-scaring periods, and especially in hunger years, villagers commonly move to their gardens. People often erect a temporary shelter in order to sleep in the fields at night to scare away hippos and intruding cattle. However, when a man has two wives, and dependents in the village homestead, one wife usually remains behind to keep house. This time, Mister's nuclear family abandoned the whole homestead, and Malala with it. Because BinaFosten and BinaMister were also living at their river gardens, no one knew of this abandonment for three days or more. Malala ate nothing and drank the few drops of water left in her cracked jug. BinaMister described meeting with her sister, BinaFosten, to decide how to manage the situation once word got out. BinaMister, because she had a particularly successful garden from which she ate even during the hunger, went to rescue her mother from the abandoned homestead. BinaMister carried the few possessions Malala owned, while Malala struggled the few miles to BinaMister's garden. According to BinaMister, a forty-minute journey took Malala close to five hours. When I found Malala at her daughter's garden a week after the abandonment, Malala appeared cleaner and more animated, mobile, and clearheaded than I had seen her in sixteen months, due to the improvement in food and access to water that BinaMister's presence mobilized. In this case, residence with a daughter raised her quality of living significantly and saved her from starvation induced by a grandson's abandonment.

[132](#)[Climate](#)[166](#)[Internal Migration](#)[593](#)[Family Relationships](#)[595](#)[Polygamy](#)[603](#)[Grandparents And
Grandchildren](#)[731](#)[Disasters](#)[737](#)[Old Age Dependency](#)[888](#)[Status And Treatment
Of The Aged](#)

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)